

A True Introduction

The world of digital imaging can be a daunting place for the beginner—especially when you go online and take a look at what people can accomplish with tools that at first glance seem so...well, worthless. We can't teach you creativity, but if you've got some, and you're looking to get started with digital imaging, welcome.

It'll be obvious from the following pages that this *Fast Track* is for beginners. Summer vacations will soon be upon us (well, you—we work all year round), and we've got to get something to occupy those idle hands, don't we?

So here we are, starting with the very basics. In the first chapter, we'll go through many of the terms you're going to encounter in this area, and how to apply basic edits to your photos (or artwork, as the case may be).

Once you've cut your teeth on that, we'll take a trip through more advanced image editing techniques—right from working with Camera Raw images, to changing colour tones to turning a perfectly innocuous image into a psychedelic monstrosity. Then come the layers....

Image compositing is a highly underestimated art. It seems like the simple act of slapping one image on to the other, but it's so much more. All those hoaxes you've seen on the Internet—the ghost in the digital photo, the ultra-creepy mermaid skeleton, the...ahem...fake nudes—all made through the magic of compositing. We're not going to teach you how to create your own fake pornography, but by the end of this chapter, you might be skilled enough to do so anyway.

Another facet of the imaging realm is the vector illustration. It can be difficult to fathom, but if you're ever planning to work with the print media or even Flash-based projects, understanding vector graphics is a crucial skill to have.

And finally, when you grow beyond the scope of this *Fast Track* (as you inevitably must), you can take to the Web to refine your skills, and show your work to the world!